

How much India should trade with Russia must not be guided by Western diktat

Between 2020-21 and 2024-25, India's imports from Russia have **soared** from \$5.5 billion to \$63.8 billion, much of it **on account of** mineral fuels (\$2.1 billion to \$56.9 billion). Out of the 244.5 million tonnes (mt) of **crude** petroleum that India imported last **fiscal**, Russia's share was over 87.5 mt, making it the country's top supplier. It's this trade that US President Donald Trump is now targeting by threatening to **levy** a "penalty", **on top of** the 25 per cent general **tariff** on Indian goods imports that he announced on Wednesday. By not specifying how much that additional penalty would be, he is basically **nudging** India to cut down, if not stop, energy (and defence) purchases from Russia. This comes just over two weeks after NATO Secretary General Mark Rutte warned India, China and Brazil of secondary **sanctions** if they continued to do business with Russia and help **sustain** its current war spending against Ukraine.

Whatever be the **quantum**, if at all, of the penalty — a new bill introduced in the US Congress **seeks to impose** a 500 per cent duty on all goods and services imports from countries "that knowingly engage in the exchange of Russian-origin uranium and petroleum products" — one thing is certain: The Western sanctions **noose is tightening**. For India, too, **buying** Russian oil **cannot** be business as before. The Narendra Modi government has **so far** — rightly — not been defensive over massively **stepping up** sourcing of Russian crude that is available at a discount relative to global **benchmark** prices. It has **cited** both the need to prioritise the energy security of India's people as well as the fact that the **ban** on imports of Russian oil by the US or European Union **is** not covered under any United Nations sanctions. **That** argument — about the purchase of this oil being well within India's **legitimate** and moral rights — still **holds**.

Pragmatic and **matter-of-fact considerations** have informed its expanding trade with Russia, even at the risk of Western **displeasure**, but at the same time, there are geopolitical costs. Those costs could significantly go up, as **the EU and US** (the Trump administration seems to have **closed ranks**) increasingly **strike** at Russia's war machine by targeting its energy revenue streams. **That** nearly 36 per cent of India's crude imports come from a single country **isn't** good **in the best** and safest of times. **Prudence demands** — and this is important from the **standpoint** of securing the country's long-term energy security — that **costs** beyond the immediate also **be factored in**. That would mean **diversifying** the sources of oil supply, similar to **de-risking** trade with China. Whether and how much India should trade with any country must be guided by its own national interest. **[Practice Exercise]**

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

Vocabulary

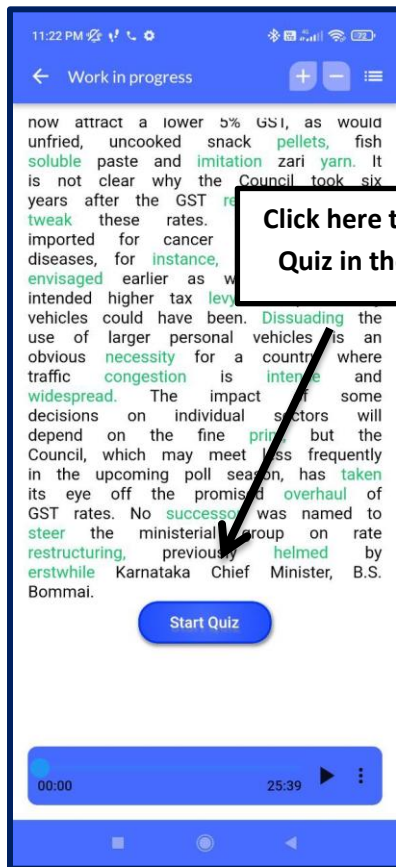
1. **Diktat** (noun) – command, decree, order, edict, mandate आदेश/ फरमान
2. **Soar** (verb) – rise, surge, escalate, increase, climb तेजी से बढ़ना
3. **On account of** (phrase) – because of, due to, owing to, as a result of, thanks to की वजह से
4. **Crude** (adjective) – unrefined, raw, unprocessed, coarse, natural कच्चा
5. **Fiscal** (noun) – financial year, revenue-related, economic, budgetary, monetary वित्तीय वर्ष
6. **Levy** (verb) – impose, charge, collect, demand, assess लगाना (कर आदि)
7. **On top of** (phrase) – in addition to, besides, as well as, over and above, beyond के अलावा
8. **Tariff** (noun) – duty, tax, levy, toll, customs शुल्क
9. **Nudge** (verb) – prompt, push, prod, urge, encourage प्रेरित करना
10. **Sanction** (noun) – restriction, penalty, embargo, ban, punitive measure प्रतिबंध
11. **Sustain** (verb) – support, maintain, uphold, prolong, preserve बनाए रखना
12. **Quantum** (noun) – amount, quantity, volume, measure, portion मात्रा
13. **Seek** (verb) – Try, attempt, endeavour, effort, प्रयास करना
14. **Impose** (verb) – enforce, establish, inflict, apply, dictate थोपना
15. **Tighten the noose** (phrase) – increase pressure, constrain, trap, intensify, restrict दबाव बढ़ाना
16. **So far** (phrase) – until now, up to this point, till date, as yet, thus far अब तक
17. **Step up** (phrasal verb) – increase, boost, escalate, intensify, raise बढ़ाना
18. **Benchmark** (noun) – standard, criterion, yardstick, reference, measure मानक
19. **Cite** (verb) – refer to, quote, mention, invoke, allude to हवाला देना
20. **Legitimate** (adjective) – lawful, valid, legal, justified, rightful वैध
21. **Hold** (verb) – remain valid, persist, endure, stay, continue बना रहना
22. **Pragmatic** (adjective) – realistic, practical, sensible, rational, logical व्यावहारिक
23. **Matter-of-fact** (adjective) – unemotional, realistic, down-to-earth, objective, practical हकीकत/ वास्तविक

24. **Consideration** (noun) – thought, reflection, deliberation, evaluation, attention विचार
25. **Displeasure** (noun) – dissatisfaction, annoyance, irritation, resentment, disapproval नाराज़गी
26. **Closed ranks** (phrase) – united, stood together, joined forces, consolidated, became cohesive एकजुट हो जाना
27. **In the best of times** (phrase) – even in favourable conditions, during good times, under ideal circumstances, normally, under usual conditions अच्छे समय में भी
28. **Prudence** (noun) – caution, wisdom, discretion, foresight, judiciousness सावधानी
29. **Standpoint** (noun) – perspective, viewpoint, position, angle, approach दृष्टिकोण
30. **Factor in** (phrasal verb) – include, consider, take into account, integrate, incorporate ध्यान में रखना
31. **Diversify** (verb) – expand, broaden, vary, spread out, branch out विविध बनाना
32. **De-risk** (verb) – reduce risk, safeguard, protect, insure, shield जोखिम कम करना

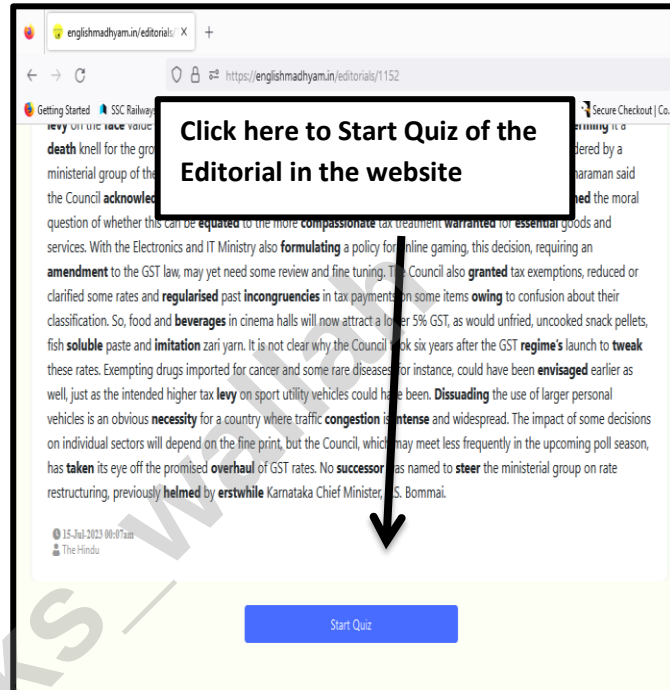
Summary of the Editorial

1. India's imports from Russia have surged from \$5.5 billion in 2020–21 to \$63.8 billion in 2024–25.
2. Mineral fuels, especially crude oil, account for the majority of this increase, rising from \$2.1 billion to \$56.9 billion.
3. In the last fiscal year, Russia became India's top crude oil supplier, delivering over 87.5 million tonnes out of 244.5 mt total imports.
4. U.S. President Donald Trump has threatened to impose a "penalty" over and above the recently announced 25% tariff on Indian imports.
5. The penalty targets India's trade with Russia, particularly in energy and defence sectors.
6. Trump's move follows NATO Secretary General Mark Rutte's warning to India, China, and Brazil of possible secondary sanctions for aiding Russia's war economy.
7. A new U.S. Congressional bill proposes a 500% duty on goods from countries trading in Russian uranium or petroleum.
8. The editorial observes that Western sanctions are intensifying, and India's energy trade with Russia will face increasing scrutiny.
9. So far, the Indian government has maintained a pragmatic stance, continuing oil purchases based on discounted prices.
10. India asserts its right to prioritise its energy security, especially as UN sanctions do not currently restrict Russian oil.
11. The moral and legal justification for India's oil trade with Russia still remains valid and defensible.
12. However, there are growing geopolitical costs associated with defying Western pressure and aligning too closely with Russia.
13. Over-reliance on one country — with 36% of crude oil imports from Russia — poses a strategic risk.
14. The editorial advises diversifying energy sources, similar to efforts to reduce dependency on China.
15. Ultimately, India's trade decisions should be driven by national interest, not by pressure or diktats from Western powers.

Practice Exercise: Banking Pattern Based



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